Investment Dating

By Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota

MEG: *(Speaking in hushed tones, with contained excited.)* Oh wow. Oh wow. Oh. Wow. I think I'm going to faint. I'm not kidding. You're not going to believe what just happened.

IRIS: *(Dryly.)* Sister Jaye had you dissect a cow eye again?

MEG: What? No. What are you talking about?

IRIS: Last time you said "You're not going to believe what just happened," Sister Jaye had you dissect a cow eye and then you passed out.

MEG: No, I didn't. Elizabeth Holt passed out. Why do you always make me out to be such a wuss?

IRIS: I don't always make you out to be a wuss. I don't need to. You are a wuss.

MEG: I just felt wobbly and pretended to faint to get out of class early.

IRIS: *(Nods and smiles.)* Uh-huh. And I suppose you had an incredible need to smash your face into the floor pattern when you watched me get my ears pierced too?

MEG: *(Cringes.)* Well, it ... was hot in there.

IRIS: Just admit it, Meg. You have a weak stomach. You pass out. No big deal.

MEG: But I don't! I don't have a weak stomach. I'm cool!

IRIS: I didn't say you weren't cool. You're a cool person who faints. 'Member when they forced us to watch that National Geographic wildlife special and the mountain lion tore the guts out of the-

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MEG: All right! I remember. Ewww. Let's think about something else. *(Trying to get the image out of her mind. Singing.)* La, la, la!

INTRODUCTION

Actress Playing Iris: (While Meg is still la, la la-ing) Meg and I have been friends for ever. BFFs for those of you who are into acronyms. I'd do anything for her. (FREEZE)
Actress Playing Meg: Did Iris just say "anything?" Perfect! Now I just have to figure out the best way to ask her. . . .
Actress Playing Iris: (UNFREEZE) Ask me what?
Actress Playing Meg: Ummmm, nothing . . . Hey are you going to the homecoming dance? Do you have a date yet? (FREEZE)
Actress Playing Iris: Uh, oh . . . this is NOT going to be good. When you've known Meg for as long as I have, you KNOW when she has something up her sleeve.
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IRIS: *(Soothing her by patting her back.)* I can just imagine how you felt when Sister Jaye put her scalpel into the cow's

MEG: All right! You're doing this on purpose. How did we get here? I was telling you about my good thing and suddenly we're dissecting cow eyes and wandering down woozy lane.

IRIS: Feeling fainty is a good thing?

MEG: You know very well that I was being ... I was exaggerating. I'm excited. I'm not actually feeling fainty. I just have this incredible feeling. It's like I've lost all my senses.

IRIS: And this is a happy thing? To lose your senses?

MEG: *(She smiles.)* Yes, it is.

IRIS: No wonder there are so many happy Republicans [Democrats] right now.

MEG: Don't be so cynical, Iris.

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IRIS: So don't be so sappy. It encourages my cynical-ness. I have to counterbalance the "S" factor. So what is it exactly, not that I really want to know?

MEG: Well. *(Quietly, out of the side of her mouth.)* You-know-who *(Nodding her head in a backward direction very subtly.)* asked me to you-know-what.

IRIS: Well, that clarifies things. *(Looking over toward her nod.)* Which who? Which what?

MEG: *(Grabbing her.)* Well, don't look!!

IRIS: How am I supposed to know who the *(Quietly.)* you-know-who is then?

MEG: How can you be so remedial? How many you-know-who's have I mentioned? *(Iris gives Meg a look.)* OK. Good point. But this is the you-know-who that has been the you-know-who since forever.

IRIS: Really? You're kidding? *(Eyes widening. Mouth drops. Beat.)* Are you telling me you have a date with *(Whispers with reverence.)* Kevin? The guy? Mason?

MEG: Oh. No, no. Not that forever. That's last month's forever! Think more recent, more do-able, and more short.

IRIS: *(Thinks.)* Jason Harley?

MEG: Not Oompa-loompa! Short. Less wow than Kevin Mason, but more smart. My guy sang in the talent show. He always rests his feet on the back of my chair. He gave me his eraser a couple days ago. To keep. Remember? *(Iris has no idea.)* He blinks a lot and he has this cute dent in his face.

IRIS: Dent? In his face? I'm sure if you mentioned this guy, you didn't mention this dent thing. That I would have remembered.

MEG: The dent crinkles so cute when he smiles.

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IRIS: So it's like a dimple or more of a full-size crater?

MEG: Yeah, well, I guess it is more like a dimple

IRIS: OK, erasing the Elephant Man image.

MEG: He's got a great personality, but he doesn't talk really.

IRIS: At all?

MEG: Very little. I mean, how much is really necessary?

IRIS: *(Nods.)* Some. For instance, if I were in a crisis situation ... like maybe my house was burning or my mother was angry because my boyfriend and I were coming home late from a date. I wouldn't want a strong, silent type. I'd rather have a wimpy talker. A guy who could come up with "Well, we both got food poisoning from something we ate at the salad bar at Denny's. We had to stop at my friend's house right away, Ms. Hemchak so we could ... you know. Otherwise we would have been home on time." Or, in the burning house situation, a loud, decisive "Help! Follow me!" might be good too.

MEG: Well, sure. In a crisis, but otherwise ... Personally, I don't want a boyfriend who blabbers on and on and on. That's why I have you.

IRIS: Thanks. So let me ask you this. How do you know he has such a great personality if he doesn't talk?

MEG: He doesn't even have one zit!

IRIS: You're kidding? Find out what he washes with!

MEG: OK, but can we get back to the point.

IRIS: I think I'm lost on the who. Maybe we should start with the you-know-what instead.

MEG: The homecoming dance, Iris! I've been talking about it for the last two

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weeks!

IRIS: That was anticlimactic. Let's hope the "who" has a little more umph.

MEG: Well, he has *the* goldfish. *(Iris looks terribly confused.)*

IRIS: "The" goldfish. *(Meg nods.)* Is this the only one left in the international community?

MEG: It's the goldfish in the science lab. He won the goldfish last year in the spelling contest and donated it. *(Iris is still perplexed.)* His last name is also the name of an animal.

IRIS: The fish?

MEG: No! The guy who asked me to homecoming. Look. It's *(Mouths "Alex Fox" several times as Iris tries to guess.)*

IRIS: Hal Thomas? Our Spanish teacher? That's sick! Although potentially advantageous.

MEG: No, no. *(Continues to mouth "Alex Fox.")*

IRIS: AI. Al-Ia. Alan? Allan Nicholson?! Oh? *(Thinks.)* He's cool.

MEG: No, Iris. Nicholson is not the name of an animal!

IRIS: OK, animal last name not last name of an actor who wears sunglasses and dates woman younger than his socks. Oh my gosh-animal? Is it Robin Anto-

MEG: No! His *last* name is an animal, not his *first* name. It's *(Very quietly, out of the corner of her mouth.)* Alex Fox.

IRIS: What did you say? *(Meg says "Alex Fox" again very quietly, almost inaudibly.)*

IRIS: Huh?

MEG: *(Singing.)* I just called to say, I love you. *(Iris' curiosity is piqued. The name*

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sounds familiar, but she's still unsure. She thinks. Meg does some weird dance move with her hand.}

IRIS: *(Yells.)* Alex Fox!

MEG: *(Grabbing Iris' face to stop her yelling. Meg speaks from the side of her mouth.)* Stop! *(Pulling her into a huddle.)* He'll hear you. He's right over there.

IRIS: Where? *(Looks. Meg pushes her arm to stop the head turning.)* He can't hear us over there. That's all the way across the cafeteria.

MEG: Don't look! He'll think we're talking about him. He probably just heard you.

IRIS: No, he didn't, but he's going to know we're talking about him because you're doing that thing again.

MEG: What thing?

IRIS: That thing you always do when you think people can hear you when they can't. That side-of-the-mouth thing that makes you look like you have palsy or something.

MEG: *(She does it.)* I'm not doing anything with my mouth. I'm just talking quietly.

IRIS: *(Imitating Meg.)* Yes, you are. You just don't know it.

MEG: Oh my God. That does look bad. *(She stops the mouth thing.}*

IRIS: So Alex Fox, huh? He's kinda boring. I mean, he doesn't talk. At all.

MEG: He sings.

IRIS: True. But not well.

MEG: I thought he was great in the talent show. And cute. All the girls did.

IRIS: What girls?

MEG: Well, I don't know. I thought he was cute.

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IRIS: He was. Sort of. For an awkward pubescent white boy with no pitch, no confidence, and no sense of rhythm.

MEG: That's not true! He had confidence. He was probably downright cocky or he wouldn't have gotten up in front of everyone to, to ...

IRIS: To embarrass himself so completely? *(Patting her.)* Anyway, I'm happy for you, Meg. Have fun.

MEG: No, don't do that talking down to me thing. You sound like I've stooped.

IRIS: Well, obviously you don't mind stooping.

MEG: I do mind stooping. I don't want to live with this feeling that I'm just some big stooper and that's it. I thought this was good-going to the dance.

IRIS: I just think if you were going to agree to go with Alex Fox, you might as well stoop down into the depths of desperation, do some more charity work, and pick up Fred Murphy on the way.

MEG: *(Laughs.)* Well, that's funny.

IRIS: What? What's funny?

MEG: Well, Alex and Fred are pretty good friends. Funny you mention Fred.

IRIS: Uh-huh. So? Where does the funny come in?

MEG: Didn't you say once ... ? I remember. You said that Fred, although a *bit* of a cretin, was ... funny, ... special, and ... specially funny.

IRIS: *(Beat.}* I did not.

MEG: I know you did. You definitely said he was funny and special.

IRIS: Well, I might have used the word ... *funny.* Perhaps I even used the word *special,* but you must have misinterpreted my meaning.

MEG: Well, see?

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IRIS: See what?

MEG: Maybe I misinterpreted, or maybe you meant it in multiple ways. Because maybe Fred is special to you in some ways.

IRIS: He is. In a mock-and-make-fun-of sort of way. Where is this heading, Meg?

MEG: Well, guys don't like to go to dances alone.

IRIS: True. They don't know where to pin the corsage.

MEG: No, I mean they like to go in a group with a date *and* a best friend.

IRIS: OK, you know what? I'm late for Spanish.

MEG: *(Grabbing her.)* Wait, Iris! You've got to do this.

IRIS: Ohhhhhh. Nooooo! I don't *have* to do anything, Meg. I'm not being pulled into another Bob Alberts fiasco.

MEG: He wasn't that bad!

IRIS: He tried to French kiss me with gum in his mouth. I had a spontaneous and relentless gag reflex and almost choked to death!

MEG: But Fred wants to take you so bad. He likes you. He really likes you!

IRIS: No, he can't! I won't let him! Don't you let him! Uh! Me? Me?! *(She points to herself. Meg nods.)* Why is this happening? What is it about me that's such a magnet for the festering warts of humanity?

MEG: You're funny and a vegetarian and read philosophy.

IRIS: *(Hitting her hand.)* That was a rhetorical question!

MEG: You're different, Iris, and lots of guys like that. Not easy to peg.

IRIS: *(Beat. Sweetly.)* You're different too, Meg. In a rotten, horrible, nightmarish, diabolical way. Now, leave me alone in my misery,

MEG: So will you at least think about it?

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IRIS: I'm saying I would rather hang from the gym by my fingernails, be mocked by my fellow art students, and forced to listen to my sister's Britney Spears CDs for twenty-four hours than go to the dance with you and Alex Fox and Fred Murphy.

MEG: Oh please, please, Iris. Just this once. I promised Alex we'd double-date.

IRIS: So un-promise him.

MEG: I can't. I told him it was a sure thing. *(Begging.)* Oh please. Pretty please. *(Iris shakes her head no.)* Don't do this to me. This is my life at stake.

IRIS: Well, if Alex is your life, you deserve to perish.

MEG: What if I pay you?

IRIS: *(Shocked.)* What? Are you serious? *(Meg nods.)* Sell my company for ... Sell my body, my spirit like some cheap call girl! That's disgusting! How much?

MEG: How much is necessary?

IRIS: *(Beat. Taking this in.)* How much you got?

MEG: Twenty? *(Iris shakes her head with disapproval.)* Twenty-five? Come on!

IRIS: For a whole night with a guy who will ruin my reputation for years to come? I don't think you're accounting for the long-range ramifications. I'd consider forty.

MEG: Forty?! I don't have forty, Iris! I've never had forty, ever! Uh! OK, thirty-seven fifty. And that's the best I can do. I'll have to borrow the two fifty from my brother, which you know I can't stand. So what do you say? *(Getting on knee.)* Please? Please?!

IRIS: *(Thinks. Sighs.)* I'm such a good friend to you, Meg.

MEG: *(Jumping for joy.)* Yah! All right! You'll probably even have fun! Fred seems

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really nice.

IRIS: He ate glue, Meg.

MEG: He was just trying to see if it would kill him. He's scientific!

IRIS: He's disturbed.

MEG: He's one of those late bloomers who will probably be a looker in early college ... or maybe not, but he'll invent some incredible computer program that will change the way we do business for years to come. He'll be a multi-millionaire in a few years and with some help, perhaps from a psychologist or even Dr. Phil, he may become a full-fledged well-rounded human being who you can write about in your depressive autobiography when you get about twenty something.

IRIS: He ate glue, Meg. He ate glue. *(Puts out her hand.)* So pay up!

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